DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Why Do We Have to Die?

Derech Hashem 1:3:6-8

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 1, Chapter 3, paragraphs 6-8 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 25 January 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we are in Chapter 3

Chapter 3 is about the nature of mankind. The Rabbi recapped the previous class:

- Man is a composition of guf and neshamah, body and soul, and this is necessary for the whole "battle" between good and bad.
- The battle only lasts for the years of this life. Since Hashem's goodness is far greater than the opposite, the time of battle is fixed, while the time of reward is eternal.
- So the world must exist in two states. During the time of avodah there must be both good and bad, because without bad there is no choice, and without choice Hashem's plan is not activated. In the World to Come, the soul is in control and the body is drawn after it, without the constant tug of war of this world.
- The Ramhal holds that there is a body in the World to Come, but a refined and elevated one.

A participant asked whether that state resembles Adam before the sin. The Rabbi said to a certain extent, but certainly not the same, since Adam still had the battle in front of him and had to choose.

The Ramhal had ended the last class by saying we must now look at mankind before and after the sin of Adam, because there is a great difference.

Paragraph 6: Adam as he was created

When Adam was created he was in exactly the state described: a composition of two opposites, body and soul, with good and bad before him, standing between them to choose. "Adam's got the same choice which we have every day of our lives."

A participant suggested Adam was more evenly balanced than we are ("No internet"). The Rabbi asked him to hold the thought.

It was fitting for Adam to choose good, so that his soul would prevail over his body and his intellect over his physical side. Then comes the key line: had he done so, he would have been perfected immediately, and would have remained in that perfection forever.

Why we die

The Rabbi stopped to explain, because this is very important. Why do we die? Only because of the sin of Adam.

Really, when we choose good, the soul has won that day's battle, and it should begin to refine the body. Every time we do good we should feel the body elevated, and when we do bad, feel it come down. But we do not. Because of the sin of Adam, the soul can no longer refine the body in its current state. The body must first go through decomposition. Only once it has decomposed and is renewed at the resurrection, reunited with the soul, can the soul begin to refine and elevate it.

Before the sin, that is how man was programmed: choose good, the soul wins, it begins to rectify and elevate the body, and so you continue for eternity. "Death is not necessary." Adam would have been completed and rested in eternity, without death.

Just one test? A participant asked whether Adam had only to pass that first test. The Rabbi said yes: "Just one test. That's it." Remember the purpose of creation: Hashem wants to give us the good, but we must choose it. Once you have chosen and incorporated the goodness within you, why choose again? Another asked whether Adam had any other choices before the serpent. The Rabbi noted that Adam was created on Friday morning and sinned by the tenth hour, and the only command we are told of is not to eat from the tree.

What about the elevated feeling after a good deed? That is not the body being refined; it is being more in touch with your soul. The body still wants what it wants, however high you are, until the day you die. The Gemara even says that the greater the person, the greater his yeser hara. "There's no concept of a person living in this world and his body being refined."

Paragraph 7: The soul's hidden power

Although we do not sense the soul doing anything other than giving us intellect and life, it has the capacity to refine and elevate the body, elevation after elevation, until the body can coexist with it in joy. Had Adam not sinned, his soul would have refined his body step by step until he was completely refined and reached eternal bliss.

Paragraph 8: Three changes after the sin

When Adam sinned, things changed greatly. From the beginning of creation there were deficiencies, and there was bad to choose. But the sin brought three changes:

1. The bad moved inside. Through the sin, deficiency increased within man himself and within all of creation. Before the sin, the temptation was external, outside of Adam (the Ramhal explains this elsewhere). After the sin it became incorporated within him, part of him. "Until now the bad is there, but it's outside of me... Now after the sin it's actually incorporated within me."

2. The repair became harder. Before, the bad was not your fault: Hashem created you with good and bad around you, and you had not done anything. It was easier to leave the deficiency and acquire perfection. Now you yourself caused the bad and increased it, so perfection is more hidden and the bad stronger, and it is not as easy to return.

3. The work is doubled. Now one must first return to the state of Adam before the sin, and only then rise to perfection. Getting back to Adam's level is "only half the job."

For these three reasons, acquiring perfection is much harder. The Rabbi added that this explains why we have 613 misvot while Adam had only one: for Adam the battle, though real, was relatively simple, whereas now a longer and more detailed tikkun is needed, and it cannot be completed in this world without passing through death.

Is the world getting worse?

The participant returned to his point: Adam was more balanced than we are, because we have added "blackness over blackness." The Rabbi agreed that we caused it. But when the participant said that since then we have made things worse and worse, the Rabbi disagreed: "I think the world's much better... than it was before," with many huge developments, though there are also things that have gone the other way.

The discussion closed with a related example about the calendar: as the ability of later generations to calculate the new month declined, Hillel II fixed the calendar, an achievement the Rabbi called perhaps greater than anything Google has done, since it was set over a thousand years ago and still works to the minute.

Summary

- Adam was created with body and soul and a choice between good and bad, just as we are.
- Had he chosen good, his soul would have refined his body and he would have lived forever; death came only through the sin.
- Since the sin, the body cannot be refined in this life; it must decompose and be renewed at the resurrection.
- The sin moved the bad inside man, made the repair harder, and doubled the work: first returning to Adam's state, then rising to perfection.
- That is why we have 613 misvot where Adam had one.

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